Queering Spirituality and Community in the Deep South

A Volume in:
Research in Queer Studies

Series Editors

Paul Chamness Iida
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Queering Spirituality and Community in the Deep South

Edited by

Kamden K. Strunk



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INTRODUCTION

Queering Spirituality and Community in the Deep South

Kamden K. Strunk

This volume is part of the *Queering the Deep South* set, which includes this book, *Queering Education in the Deep South,* and *Queering Public Health and Public Policy in the Deep South*. At first glance, the combinations of topics in this volume, spirituality and community, might feel odd. However, those familiar with the dynamics of life in the Deep South will recognize the strong, insistent link between spirituality and community that is nearly omnipresent in the region. It is often said of living in the Deep South that the first questions anyone asks on initially meeting a new person are what they do for a living, where they're from, and what church they attend. There is an implicit assumption of Christian religiousness, and religiousness pervades community life.

So committed are many in the Deep South to a religious public life that lawsuits over Christian biblical monuments on government property are nearly a constant, such as the string of lawsuits over attempts to enshrine the "Ten Commandments" on public property. Politicians campaign on their commitment to Christian morality in government (leading to the "three Gs" of "God, guns, and gays" in Southern politics). Schools and universities regularly land in hot water over the

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infusion of Christianity into the curriculum, athletic events, and writing assignments. Historically, Christian religiousness in the Deep South was weaponized for the purposes of racial violence and terror, with most efforts at racial segregation, racial violence, and racial oppression being framed in religious, Christian, terms for decades. It is not without meaning that the enduring symbol of racist terrorism in the Deep South is the burning cross.

Modern religiousness has, by and large, sought to divorce itself from those historic images, emblazoned on the minds of many. Of course, religiousness is still often used as a framework for supporting forms of racist discrimination in some circles. More commonly in the modern era, perhaps especially in the Deep South, religiousness has been weaponized against queer people and queer identities. Attempts to belittle queer individuals as "abominations", efforts to outlaw same-gender marriage as "unbiblical", and targeted harassment of trans and nonbinary individuals as "violations of God's creation" are all too common in the modern Deep South. The rise of so-called religious freedom laws, which have been particularly aggressive in the South, is a direct response to the push for full equality under the law for queer people.

In the first section of this text, authors take up the intersections of religiousness, spirituality, and queer identities. Jacob Glazier interrogates the spiritual practices used in the Deep South through the lens of queer theory, tracing the effects of the African diaspora in Southern spirituality. Christian Chan and Philip Daniels apply the lenses of queer theory and intersectionality to understand how queer spiritualities operate in the Deep South. Danielle Hurd theorizes music in the Southern Black church as a means of queer transgressive action. Finally, Denise Levy describes the experience of growing up queer in the Southern Christian church.

The second section of this text takes up a specific incarnation of religiousness in Southern public life, namely the rise of the religious right and Anita Bryant. Hillary Anderson chronicles the ways in which lesbian women in the South responded to and worked against the so-called "Save Our Children" crusade led by Bryant. Robert Byrd Jr., Melissa Janoske, and Audrey Chaney document the same period early in the rise of the religious right under Anita Bryant, but do so from the perspective of how the news media covered that movement.

Taken together, these authors paint a compelling picture of the nature of spirituality and religiousness in the South, how queer people have interacted with that spirituality and religiousness, and how it has been mobilized for anti-queer political purposes in the religious right. These pieces focus specifically on spirituality and how it connects with, collides with, and works against queer lives and queer liberation in the South. The third section of this text includes pieces that, though they might touch on religiousness and spirituality, investigate the broader themes of community life in the South. Daniel Manuel documents the development of queer liberation efforts in Lafayette, Louisiana. Jerry Watkins similarly documents the development of queer-inclusive spaces (and the pushback against that development) in Pensacola, Florida. Together, these two pieces show how

queer issues developed differently in locales within the Deep South based on local and contextual factors. Elyse Ambrose and Benae Beamon take a biographical approach to understanding particular Black queer identity expressions and the taking up of queer agency by central personalities in the queer South. Michael Bartone documents the experiences of gay men from Atlanta, Georgia and interrogates how those experiences are shaped both by their location in a large urban area and their placement in the Deep South. Finally, Melanie Lantz, Sarah McConnell, Brittan Davis, and Emily Burish provide a narrative account of queer community life in the Deep South through the words of queer Southerners.

The pieces in this text, collectively, contribute to an understanding of lived dynamics in the Deep South. The intersections of right-wing Christian ideological domination with white supremacist heteropatriarchy are clearly evident throughout these pieces, which often shine a glaring light on the intersections of race, gender, sexual identity, spirituality, religiousness, and place. Several pieces also offer some hope of ways in which queer communities have created affirming spaces, worked for liberation, and achieved real and meaningful change.

SECTION 1

QUEER SPIRITUALITIES

CHAPTER 1

SPIRITUAL PRACTICES IN THE DEEP SOUTH

Queer Theory and the African Diaspora

Jacob W. Glazier

Given the continued influence the African Diaspora still exerts over the present day southern United States, this extant pressure may contain ways in which to directly challenge hegemonic structures of oppression—most notably, conservative Christianity. Queer theory may, likewise, be best suited in this pursuit as a strategic and allied partner, especially given the challenges LGBTQ individuals have faced in the Bible Belt. The spiritual practices that have been directly influenced by the African Diaspora, such as Louisiana Voodoo and Santería, put "queer" pressure on Christian normativity by offering an alternative pragmatics of worship—one that does not defer desire to the next life but, instead, sees an animistic intertwining of life, world, and universe.

She come walkin' into Congo Square wit' her head up in the air like a queen. Her skirts swished when she walked and everybody step back to let her pass. All the people—white and colored—start sayin' that's the most powerful woman there is. They say, "There goes Marie Laveau!" (as cited in Fandrich, 1996, p. 613)

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pages 3–16.
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This description of the most famous Voodoo queen from New Orleans, Marie Laveau, demonstrates the enduring influence African tribal traditions have had in the southern United States. In an article analyzing the myth-making process surrounding the legendary Voodoo priestess, Fandrich (1996) cites the quote from the former slave Tom Bragg who was interviewed at the age of 95 by the Writers' Project in the 1940s when this story was recounted. During the lifetime of Marie Laveau, the site of the Congo Square in New Orleans, as Frandrich (1996) relates, "was the only officially sanctioned space in North America where enslaved people of African descent were allowed to publicly perform" (p. 614). Congo Square was not only the epicenter of public displays of general tribal culture, like song, music, and dance, but it also brought together the more secretive and guarded parts of these traditions, practices that included Voodoo, magical talismans, and ritual magic.

The need to keep safe such practices, at least during that time, was to avoid persecution or death by the state and other institutional authorities like the Christian Church (Chireau, 1997). Indeed, the exclusionary pressure that Christianity in this geographical area puts on alternative forms of spirituality, like those practiced by Marie Laveau, persists even today in not only the practicing demographic of the Church but also in the cultural and media currency that Christianity has in the Deep South—the ubiquity with which the signs and symbols associated with Christianity proliferate and enter the daily lives of the people that live in this geographic region. In order to challenge this, the following chapter will envision traditional African practices, especially those that may directly challenge the hegemony of conservative Christianity in the Deep South, as analogous to queer strategies and the lived experience of LGBTQ individuals in this very same region. To be more specific, the syncretic and counter-normative nature of queerness and African-inspired spirituality are amenable in many ways and offer an alternative to the most widely circulating forms of Christianity.

However, it is with caution that this thesis is advanced since there exists hostility toward LGBTQ people from some Christian groups rooted in Africa. An example of this is the Anglican Communion's stance against same-sex marriage and the sanctioning of the Episcopal Church for practicing same-sex marriages (Domonoske, 2016). The common narrative that surrounds Africa typically views the continent as an overall hostile place for LGBTQ acceptance, let alone celebration. The recent push by African nations to suspend an official independent rights monitor of the United Nations whose task is to investigate crimes against LGBTQ individuals is indicative of this general sentiment of animosity (Nichols, 2016). While these examples point to the challenges that still lie ahead, in large part, this chapter positions such issues as a remnant of colonialism manifested most symptomatically, perhaps, in Africa itself. Importantly, the phrase "African-inspired spirituality" refers to histories, myths, practices, and anecdotes that originated from a pre-colonized Africa. This is not to suggest a return to these traditions, an impossibility given the complexity of colonialism, but the use of these experi-

ences, allied with their queer conceptual and material linkages, to challenge the contemporary power that colonialism has to subjugate.

The African Diaspora frames this problematic, the suppression of indigenous and tribal beliefs and rituals, and exerts a strong and ongoing influence over the present day southern United States. The historical shockwaves of the African Diaspora that reverberate today have implications for globalization (Bond, 2006) and, with regard to the current analysis, Christianity. This chapter uses queer theory to try and listen to some of these reverberations in order to analyze how some of the spiritual imported practices and beliefs from the African Diaspora align, quite intimately, with what it means to be queer.

THE AFRICAN DIASPORA AS A FRAME OF REFERENCE

As a symptom of the colonialist project initiated by mostly European powers from the sixteenth to the nineteenth century (Manning, 1992), the African Diaspora, as it has come to be known in the academic literature, was "the largest transoceanic migration in history up to that time" (Klein, 2010, p. 75). This forced migration was carried out through the transportation of native and indigenous Africans across the Atlantic Ocean, making up the Atlantic slave trade—the shipping of enslaved bodies to the Americas. This form of forced labor and commodified servitude transported approximately 12 million slaves (Manning, 1992) to islands in the West Indies, including Jamaica, Hispaniola (Haiti and the Dominican Republic), Puerto Rico, other Caribbean islands, and the continental Americas. It was not, however, exclusively European states who were interested in the practice of extracting this type of labor. Manning (1992) estimates about 6 million people were issued from sub-Saharan Africa to the Asian markets and about 8 million were retained within the African continent as slaves (p. 119).

The concept of *diaspora* (διασπορά) derives from the Greek language and can be etymologically translated into English as dispersion or scattering (Diaspora, n.d.). This meaning was applied first and foremost to the Jewish exile out of the land of Israel as detailed, for instance, in the Torah. However, in more recent times and within the academic literature, the concept of diaspora has come to represent a broader theoretical framework by which to look at similar political, economic, religious, cultural, and demographic movements. Such movements are, importantly, not voluntary and, consequently, do not happen by way of a natural, indigenous, or internal progression. Butler (2001), in conversation with other researchers in the field of diaspora studies, states that the term diaspora, in its simplest form, can be defined as the dispersal of people from their original homeland. Butler claims that, specifically within the field of African Diaspora scholarship, researchers tend to forget the genealogical, etymological, and historical roots of the word.

Comparing the African Diaspora to the literature on the Jewish Diaspora, Butler (2001) makes the point that there has been a historical precedent to distinguish between "*galut* (exile) from *tephutzot* (voluntary dispersal)" (p. 191). This distinction, when being applied to the African Diaspora, may serve to help frame

the semantics of the problem and, as a result, the direction of research. In other words, by seeing the African Diaspora as a *galut*, a brutal and forced migration stemming from European colonialism, present day analyses are better prepared to understand how this historical event continues to affect the contemporary state of the world. In contrast, a *tephutzot* frame would obfuscate and erase the internal power dynamics and the political agendas that went toward making such an event as the African Diaspora possible in the first place thereby unjustly denying the role played by state actors or transnational interests. Consequently, it is impossible to understand current planetary phenomena, such as globalization and capitalism, without taking into account the conditions that made these mobilizations of commodities possible (i.e., the influence the African Diaspora still exerts over the present day).

Indeed, Wofford (2016) foregrounds the contemporary power the African Diaspora still brings to bear using an aesthetic and economic lens going so far as to see its project not in the mere trafficking of bodies (which it was) but, perhaps more broadly and insidiously, as a certain symptom of colonialist policy, globalization, and technological mediation. In its expansive form, using Wofford as a lead, the term diaspora takes on more of a semiological and coded function such that it is the reduction of virtually all systems of meaning into a forced, albeit less disembodied, form of exile. As a case in point, Wofford (2016) writes that this applies to "communities, cultures, individuals, and even art objects [that are] spread globally under the conditions of late capitalism" (p. 74). The virtualization of diaspora, through mechanisms that proliferate in the everyday lives of most humans on the planet, like computing and popular media, make understanding its historical antecedents all the more pressing.

In a certain way, then, the concept of diaspora is helpful in framing a twofold sense by which to analyze life in the southern United States in the present day: the literal enslavement and forced migration of bodies across the Atlantic Ocean and into this geographical region, as well as the pressure this event puts on contemporary discursive formations. The technical term *hegemony*, taken from the Marxist thinker Gramsci (2014), may help conceptualize the power exerted by these discursive structures. Hegemony is essentially the institutional and historic power afforded to the dominant class. Being more precise within the scope of this chapter, the African Diaspora, through the continued impact of indigenous spiritual practices, those like ritual magic and the use of grimoires, places pressure on hegemonic structures, forms of spirituality that are institutionalized and given cultural cachet. In the southern United States, this religious tradition happens to be Christianity.

RECASTING CHRISTIANITY IN THE DEEP SOUTH

It is difficult to overestimate the strong ideological and reactionary strains of Christianity, those like evangelical Protestantism, that populate and impact the Deep South of the United States. Indeed, the region that runs from the Atlantic

coast, the Carolinas, Georgia, and upper Florida, and west through most of Texas is known idiomatically and sometimes scholastically as the Bible Belt (Brunn, Webster, & Archer, 2011). This geographical designation is primarily due to these groups possessing more exclusionary sociological norms and a religious practice that relies on an authoritarianism of textuality and the transcendent nature of salvation, at least more so than other regions in the rest of the United States. The phrase *Christian fundamentalism* may most succinctly capture this sense. Pratt (2010) writes that Christian *fundamentalism* must also be understood in relation to Christian *extremism*. Pratt suggests that extremism connotes degrees of intensity and is more likely to produce terroristic actions as the actors involved view themselves as being the center, as opposed to being on the margins, of their particular religious traditions. Fundamentalism, on the other hand, is typically used to refer "to a set of specific Christian beliefs and an allied ultra-conservative attitude" (Pratt, 2010, p. 440). In other words, fundamentalism connotes more of the ideological or belief systems of the extremist groups. Inherent, also, in the Christian Deep South and being more on the side of extremism, is a strong tendency toward proselytism (Freston, 2009). This recursively feeds rigid boundaries and the stagnancy of beliefs and values insofar as going out and proselytizing requires an individual first of all believe strongly that their point of view is worth sharing and, secondly, that this very belief requires that others need to believe the same.

If the Bible Belt helps name a certain religious hegemony present in the Deep South, then its establishment as such would not have been possible without the lasting effects of the African Diaspora. That is, there is an historical connection between the importation of slaves and the Christian fundamentalism and extremism found in the Deep South. This is partially due to the indoctrination and proselytization forced upon the African people and the subsequent smashing of their indigenous and spiritual beliefs by the Christian Church. As a result of this process, a reactionary hegemony is being propped up by the labor extracted from not only historical and economic institutions like slavery, but also from the extant suppression of alternative forms of worship that may challenge its cultural status. In other words, the subjugated status of these alternative forms of worship keeps the hegemony alive, so to speak. The African pre-colonial forms of spirituality have, likewise, their roots also in the African Diaspora, albeit in a different non-colonial sense, one that is rooted in tribal tradition, land proximity, and genealogical commonalities. The belief systems of these traditions, which include many of the proper African religions like Yoruba and Vodun (Thorpe, 1991), were imported into the New World and reworked against the pragmatics, the material, political, and semiotic realities, that the new territory called for—an excellent example being Santería (Brandon, 1997). As a specific case in point, practitioners employ forms of ethnomedicine, which include the use of herbs and energy healing, practices that were once used in African and now have become re-formed and molded under Catholicism.

This rooting in the diaspora has as its benefit a certain liminal and boundary-crossing ability in that, it would seem, the practitioners resourcefully adapted, forced or not, into something new that had not existed before on their indigenous continent. Chireau (1997) articulates a similar sentiment, specifically in regard to magical practices, when writing:

> Like so many elements of African religion in the Western hemisphere, magic was transformed in the diaspora. In the American South, sources indicate that a kinship emerged between supernaturalism and slave Christianity. As Protestantism became more widely embraced and indigenized among American-born blacks, remaining elements of African magic were incorporated into organized religious life, while others were absorbed into African American folk beliefs. (p. 229)

The phenomenon of appropriating and integrating disparate domains of meaning or theological structures is known as *syncretism* in religious studies and anthropology (Sigalow, 2016) and taps into ongoing polemics about the nature of mixture, teleology, and temporality (Stewart, 1999, 2011). It is important to distinguish between the syncretic practices of the African indigenous practitioners and the colonialization of these beliefs by Christianity. The former, syncretism, is a type of appropriation that relies on more freedom and innovation as opposed to hegemonic appropriation. By contrast, the latter tends to erase and supplant indigenous beliefs as for example in the Christian takeover of what were originally Pagan holidays (Walter, 2003).

Putting the issue as a question, does syncretism convey some kind of degradation or fall of a religion from a previous pristine or whole form? Does it name a temporality predicated necessarily by change? In other words, when do syncretistic elements stop being syncretistic? When is a religion really a religion? The formative historical antecedents leading up to the African Diaspora, an event that springs from a syncretism, is difficult to name and define. This leads the diaspora's blending of elements in a state of suspension—indeed, contributing perhaps to the minor status of the forms of spirituality that are derivative of indigenous African religions and traditions.

One specific syncretic and therefore troublesome element within the larger structure of imported beliefs coming out of the diaspora is African American occultism or, as Chireau (1997) calls it, *Conjure*. The term Conjure is somewhat of a blanket term in that it covers a broad range of practices that fall outside of the scope of accepted or normative religious practices, what otherwise might be known as occult or esoteric in more Western parlance. As Chireau (1997) articulates, "the term [Conjure] applies to an extensive area of magic, practices, and lore that includes healing, spells, and supernatural objects" and, furthermore, that these kinds of spiritual techniques have "persisted in black culture, often obscured but deemed compatible with other spiritual traditions" (p. 226). The fact that these fringe beliefs have a certain persistence that resists full hegemonic initiation into the most popular religious practices and that they are, at the same time, syncreti-

cally assimilated into pre-existing religious structures must say something about their efficacy. The fact that they exist on the margins gives such spiritual practices a power to challenge the normalizing force of Christianity in the Deep South. In other words, they are difficult to appropriate precisely because the practitioners have so cunningly been able to syncretically infiltrate the theological hegemony.

Their reason for persisting, continuing to exist in spite of or because of the challenges that the diaspora posed, is due to a kind of efficaciousness, that these practices must work in some way, whether magically, politically, or culturally. The persistence of such subterranean elements was used by the African slaves as a form of cultural preservation and remembrance while, simultaneously, challenging white control. As a case in point, for Raupach (2002), the African Diaspora brought a frame to bear in the Deep South that constituted "rituals of remembrance, social bonding across racial diversity, worship of African Gods, and imagined return to the homeland [that] did in fact challenge conceptions of white superiority in colonial discourse" (para. 26). The inherent counter-hegemonic power of these beliefs and values is part and parcel of what seems to make practices like Conjure effective in the first place—that they must necessarily be transgressive in order to induce their desired effect (Bataille, 1997).

These two abstract elements of imported indigenous practices, their ecclesial syncretism and counter-hegemonic or transgressive nature, would not be complete without a more pragmatic understanding of their material effects and the claim by most, if not all, of the traditional African religions that the world could be influenced through ritual or magical practice. Some examples or ends desired by the practitioners include "the prediction of the future, the explanation of the unknown, and the control of nature, persons, and events" (Chireau, 1997, p. 227). In the Western esoteric tradition, this would be called *theurgy* (θεουργία) which represents systems and techniques aimed toward the pursuit of a goal, sometimes directed at the external world or toward personal or self-refinement (Addey, 2014; Garstin, 2004)—perhaps relying on the use of grimoires, goetias, and other invocatory texts.

An understanding of the world predicated on such an entwinement of self and other—perhaps it goes without saying given the African origins elaborated earlier (c.f., Garuba, 2003)—would have to be a form of post-anthropocentric animism. Such a worldview grants an interwoven and processual status to beings of all kinds including humans, animals, plants, spirits, thoughts, emotions, and so forth. This does not entail, however, that all beings are given equal value. As many of adepts in this paradigm will explain, certain objects or entities, for instance talismans in Conjure (Chireau, 1997) or the Loa in Haitian Voodou (Filan, 2006), are more powerful and therefore are attended to much more so than others.

Rather, the point is that all beings partake of the same ontological source, that they are constantly in a state of becoming with each other, and that it is precisely because of this fact that the mechanism and spiritual practices introduced by the African Diaspora are able to function—that materiality is just another category

among others. This stands in stark distinction to materialistic and isolatory cosmologies advanced by, for instance, the version of Christianity found in the Bible Belt of the Deep South, with its hierarchical clericalism and monotheistic conservatism. As a point of comparison, see the quasi-polytheistic structure that Catholicism has, its veneration and adoration of many saints, which may have made it so amenable to being appropriable by practitioners coming out of the African Diaspora, as highlighted in the case of Haitian Voodou (Desmangles, 1992).

The foregoing opens up a Pandora's box of problematics, tightly bound philosophical issues surrounding language, culture, transmission, and epistemology, to name a few. Indeed, as Pels (1998) points out, an analysis of this kind:

> Shows that present-day attempts at radical translation of African "witchcraft" must not only negotiate novel Western categories of the occult, but might also take one into a phenomenology of perception that suspends our everyday classifications of factuality, what we regard as the bedrock of sensory perception. But that suspension, of course, is terrifying: it may be a signpost on the road to psychotherapy, conversion, or madness. (p. 206)

The abandonment of sense, or the reconstituting of factuality, that Pels suggests, goes to show the tribulations associated with colonialist importing, as for example during the historical time period of the African Diaspora, while also demonstrating the ongoing appropriations of knowledges and practices by new adepts or by scholastic researchers. Indeed, the "clash" between the two, historically Western occult concepts and their African indigenous counterparts, demonstrates, as just one case in point, the contemporary pressure the African Diaspora exerts on the present day. Pushing this logic further, one might even say that the indigenous African tribal traditions, and the subcategory of theurgy and spirituality that is sheltered by this term, are more original than their Western counterparts, at least insofar as they have maintained locally and territorially a milieu that fosters their own preservation and flourishing.

QUEER THEORY AND LIVED EXPERIENCE IN THE DEEP SOUTH

The challenge that the spiritual elements of the African Diaspora exert on the Deep South and, specifically, on the ideological function that Christian fundamentalism serves, shares an alikeness to the pressure exerted by queer and LGBTQ individuals in this same region. Much literature exists on detailing the lived experience of queer people in the Bible Belt—most of which is decidedly pejorative of southern Christianity (c.f., Barton, 2010, 2012).

In the spirit of reframing the discourse, Fleischmann and Hardman (2004) conclude that "religion was not only a force in opposing the gay rights movement in Atlanta; it was also a key part of the movement's development" (p. 418). A similar principle may also be applied to other modes of resistance found throughout the Bible Belt. In other words, it is not only the hegemony of Christianity in this region but, more importantly, the kind of Christianity this hegemony hands down,

which may launch modes of resistance and forms of subversion. There is a complex relationship, in other words, between Christian religious beliefs in the Deep South and the acceptance of LGBTQ individuals. The relationship is not just one of subjugation, in other words, since spaces of affirmation exist within what may be considered the larger pervasiveness of Christian religiosity.

Different Christian Churches and congregations have welcomed LGBTQ people openly resulting in transformational experiences for both the queer individual and the larger institution (Murr, 2013). Indeed, there is much to be said for the importance of faith and religion, particularly Christianity, in the lives of African Americans living in the South, both anecdotally (Evans, 2008) and methodologically (Lassiter, 2015), especially those families that can trace their heritage to the Deep South through multiple generations. Even much of the civil rights movement was rooted in a certain Christian religiosity, which in some ways speaks to the fact of how intricate the link between Christianity and being African American is and has been in the Deep South (Harvey, 2016). In relation specifically to queer lives, however, the role of the Church in the Deep South has been historically egregious and being black and queer complexifies the matter even more so.

Given the unique mixture of ethnicities, histories, identities, and spiritual beliefs that can be found in the southern United States, queer theory, with its procedures to challenge normativity, privilege, and even standard notions of right and wrong, may aid in conceptualizing the geopolitical pocket known as the Deep South. Indeed, queer theory, just like the material lives of LGBTQ individuals themselves, poses a threat to meta structures of power and subjugation. More concretely, add in the spiritual elements of the African Diaspora and the threat to hegemonic institutions, like Christianity, becomes all the more menacing. In fact, it may be the very syncretic nature of the "queer" in its figural status as theoretical trope and material body coupled with a homologous syncretism unique to magical, theurgic, or esoteric practices coming out of the African Diaspora, which could have the power to liberate and equalize such subterranean modes of being.

As a general definition, Dean (2003) articulates the inclusivity that queer studies brings to bear on politics and social arrangements by suggesting that queer stands for all those individuals that are excluded from the general population, including those that fall under the categories of sexuality, race, class, or nationality. As a consequence, according to Dean (2003), queer does not denote a "particular sexual orientation or a stigmatized erotic identity," rather represents "a critical distance from the white, middle-class, heterosexual norm" (p. 240). In this way, queer may designate a certain theoretical or scholastic posture relative to normativity inasmuch as it necessarily stands outside the *status quo*.

This is, again, a more abstract conceptualization of queerness than the acronym LGBTQ would allow for in that "queer sets itself more broadly in opposition to the forces of normalization that regulate social conformity" (Dean, 2003, p. 240). Such an oppositional stance to the *status quo* is known as the antisocial thesis in queer studies (Halberstram, 2008), which generally holds the position that the

very term queer represents a certain lack or negativity that makes it impossible to be grasped and assimilated into overarching structures of meaning and power—building a bridge, syncretically and teleologically, between now and what is to come.

The incisiveness, in its strongest form, inherent to queer beings is perhaps taken the furthest by Edelman (2004) when the theorist suggests that "the queer dispossesses the social order of the ground on which it rests" (p. 6). This is due, as per the thesis Edelman advances, to the special kind of temporality inherent to queerness and its relation to the social order; namely, by rejecting futurity, a sense of time predicated on the continued smooth functioning and growth of sociality, the value placed on reproduction and posterity drawn from the innocent gaze of the child, queer figures, whether literal embodied individuals or theoretical concepts and tactics, undercut hegemonies of all kinds. This shares a similar quality with the spiritual practices taken from the African Diaspora, the threat these ways of being posed to slave owners and institutional white power.

What is more, the degree to which the hegemony represses the manifest value of queerness is correlative to the degree that it will find itself threatened: "the queer insists that politics is always a politics of the signifier, or even of what Lacan will often refer to as 'the letter'" (Edelman, 2004, p. 6). It follows, then, that given the literality by which the queer denatures the meaning of politics, policing the way it constructs meaning apart from the signifier as such, the conservatism inherent to the strain of Christianity found in the Deep South represents, at least in the United States, a paragon case of antagonism and enmity between Church authority and queer subversion. Such a queer subversion is similar to the pressure put on Christian fundamentalism by the African Diaspora in the southern United States.

Just like the African esoteric practices discussed earlier, the important point is that one should not talk about them, not just to safeguard generational secrets or powerful spells, but in order to limit the space or territory they take up in discourse. The silence cuts both ways, between mainstream Church acceptance and the strategic reclaiming of subjectivity in that one must become selective in sharing for reasons of self-preservation and sustainability. With queerness, too, the rule is hush-hush. As a case in point, one may take, as Sedgwick (1990) does, the hypostasis of gender as controlling the way that discourses and institutions perpetuate themselves, a disavowal at the heart of individual bodies and the production of subjectivities, that maintains existing conditions of power and discrimination: "oppressions of gender can have a structuring force for nodes of thought, for axes of cultural discrimination, whose thematic subject isn't explicitly gendered at all" (p. 34). Indeed, the very construction of gender as a concept and something that can be named goes toward suppressing those individuals who may fall under subcategories that are not valued by normative forces—identities like female, transgender, queer, and so on.